

of years, there was little progress of any sort, which was reflected in static human populations with static levels of well-being.

Then, after 1765, progress took off like a rocket. Over the next 200 years, the lives of people in the developed countries and the human population, generally, changed completely.

It took 199,700 years for the human population to go from zero to 125 million. But over the next 250 years, it added about 6 billion people. Every 5 years, approximately, it added the equivalent of the entire world's population in 1750. "Progress" made it possible. People had much more to eat. Better sanitation. Better transportation, which eliminated famines by making it possible to ship large quantities of food into areas where crops had failed. The last major famine due to failed crops in western Europe occurred in the eighteenth century. After that, the famines, in the developed world at least, have been intentional—caused largely by government policies.

Progress permitted huge increases in population. And it brought rising real wages and rising standards of living.

By the late twentieth century, people in the developed world took progress and gross domestic product (GDP) growth for granted. Governments went into debt, depending on future growth to pull them out. So did corporations, insurance companies, pension firms, and ordinary households. Everyone counted on growth. Spending and tax policies were based on encouraging growth. Whenever growth stalled, governments rushed to try to get it going again.

The enormous growth in government itself was made possible by the internal combustion engine. The more it boosted output, the richer the host economy got, the more parasitic government it could afford.

Today, there is hardly a mortgage, stock, bond, municipal plan, government budget, student loan, retirement program, housing development, business plan, political campaign, health care program, or insurance company that doesn't rely on growth. Everybody expects normal growth to resume after we have put this sluggish period behind us.

But what if growth isn't normal? What if the growth of the last two centuries was a once-in-a-centimillennium event, made possible by the discovery of new continents and cheap energy?